

Of Mice and Men: The Disillusionment of Happy Fairy Tales

As one of the most important but controversial American novels in the 20th century, *Of Mice and Men* has long been criticized for its “preoccupation with biology” and the language that John Steinbeck uses “to present life in animal terms” (Meyer, qtd. in *Of Mice and Men - Critical Reception*). However, behind Steinbeck’s cynical language is his deepest sympathy to the American proletariat during the Great Depression, who struggled in the “whole damn world” (Steinbeck, p. 18) just for “a little piece of land” (p. 36) that could become their only small warm shelter. Actually, in *Of Mice and Men*, everybody weaves his/her own happy fairy tale, hoping that one day it might come into reality, but at the end, no one ever succeeds, instead, all characters, George, Lennie, Candy, Crooks, and even Curley’s wife, have to accept the disillusionment of their fantasies. Therefore, the answer to why Steinbeck uses “bad” language, in fact, lies in the cruel and helpless reality.

Unquestionably, George and Lennie’s tragedy is the most obvious and touching example in the story that reflects the death of an American dream. To be honest, their dream is anything but ambitious, instead, their dream is small, plain, and even childish, so the best language to describe it must not be flowery or rhetoric, but should be simple yet sincere. In their eyes, ten acres of ranch that “got a little win’ mill, got a little shack on it, an’ a chicken run” (p. 28) is their palace, and an alfalfa land is their imperial garden. The happiest thing to kill time is feeding and petting a brood of soft rabbits with each other, while the worst thing to face with is that some rabbits may not survive in Lennie’s giant hands. Sadly, all what George and Lennie want is negligible compared to the wealth of any capitalist, however, even through their dream is so small and ordinary, for the proletariat, it is still fragile and inaccessible. At the end of the novel, all it needs to break their dream is just one sentence with a question mark, “Then—it’s all off?”

(p. 47). After the death of Curley's wife, George and Lennie's last silver lining vanishes irrevocably. In the foreseeable future, readers could sense that, for George, owing a small piece of land would become an impossible dream, because without Lennie, without "somebody to be near him" (p. 36), George's destiny is among millions of lonely workers, the homeless who "got nothing to look ahead to" and "ever' time a whore house or a blackjack game took what it takes (for them to buy a small piece of land)" (pp. 8, 37).

Besides George and Lennie, the chequered life experience of Candy and Crooks is also a vivid microcosm of the proletariat in the Great Depression. As an aging handyman with hand disability, the only value attached to old Candy is that he "could cook and tend the chickens and hoe the garden some" (p. 30). When he becomes too old to do any labor, such as "can't swamp out no bunk houses", undoubtedly, the boss will mercilessly "put me (Candy) on the county" (p. 30). Therefore, in order to at least make a living after being abandoned, Candy secretly saves three hundred dollars (with "fifty more comin' the end a the month" (p. 30)). As the unexpected arrival of George and Lennie rekindles his long-forgotten dream, once again, the old worker picks up his faith in the dream of owning a piece of land. Candy is not the only person whose fantastic illusion is awakened by George and Lennie, the "negro stable buck" with crooked back, Crooks, also ephemerally believes that the wonderful plan of George and Lennie is possible. As an African American, Crooks is a freak among ranch workers. From his monologue, readers can infer that Crooks used to have a warm and stable life with two brothers in California. But unfortunately, all past happiness turns into indistinct memories. Probably because of the extreme racial discrimination in America, Crooks has got nothing left and becomes suspicious of any kindness or solicitude he receives, therefore, he uses indifference and hostility as a weapon to protect himself from the outside world. The scorn from Curley's wife immediately makes Crooks

realize that his transient dream is merely a lamentable self-deception, and in response, he soon “had reduced himself to nothing... no personality, no ego — nothing to arouse either like or dislike” (p. 39) — after all, nothing could change the fact that Crooks is a “busted-back nigger”.

Ultimately, as the most hated character in the story, Curley’s wife, a young lively girl who even does not deserve a name, she is not only the murderer who kills everybody’s fairy tales, but also the victim of the hopeless, distorted American society. She might be a little vain and frivolous, but she deserves the right to become the person that she wants to be, a film star “in the movies, an’ had nice clothes” (p. 44). However, her mother forces her to marry Curley, a self-centered egomania who only cares about how to “lead with his left twicet, and then bring in the ol’ right cross” (p. 38). In this young girl’s eyes, her husband is neither considerate nor responsible — “He ain’t a nice fella” (p. 44). From the moment when Curley’s wife realizes this fact, her dream of becoming a movie star is completely disillusioned, and her only consolation is to find someone as her audience, let him sit down quietly, listen to her story, and appreciate her performance. Unfortunately, only Slim could understand Curley’s wife’s heartfelt wishes, only he “went quietly over to her... felt her wrist... one lean finger touched her cheek... and his finger explored her neck” (p. 47) after her tragic death.

In fact, the whole story of *Of Mice and Men* suddenly becomes lifeless upon Curley’s wife’s death, because what is associated to her physical death is every character’s spiritual death — the ranch, the garden, the alfalfa land, the rabbits, and the American dream of the proletariat, all vanish as mirages. Perhaps in the future, there will be some workers sitting around, playing cards, bragging about their anecdotes in some whorehouse, and dreaming that somewhere in the world an affectionate old man is selling his ranch to save his dying wife. However, this time, none of George, Lennie, Candy, and Crooks will be the protagonists again.

References

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